The Journal of Drug Issues 21(3), 651-667, 1991

THE NEW WAR ON DRUGS: GRASS ROOTS MOVEMENT OR POLITICAL CONSTRUCTION?

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The 1986 War on Drugs is analyzed from the perspective of the constructionist approach to social problems. Using the model developed by Mauss, and relying on self-report data on drug use, we argue that the objective conditions of drug use cannot explain why drugs became an issue immediately prior to the 1986 elections. Instead, explanations for the rise of drugs as a social problem are to be found primarily in the political realm. Politicians looking for a "safe" election issue took advantage of a general public concern about drug abuse by promoting drugs as a social problem. Theoretical implications for Mauss's approach are explored in a concluding section. Specifically, this model needs to be revised to allow for a more active involvement of state officials in the process of claims making.

Introduction

The use and abuse of illicit drugs have periodically been rediscovered as social problems in America for over one hundred years (Mauss 1975; Peyrot 1984). The 1986 War on Drugs was the most recent example of the social construction of drug problems. While the focus of earlier analyses of the social construction of drug problems has emphasized individual moral entrepreneurs (Becker 1963; Lindesmith 1965; Reasons 1974; Trebach 1982) or organizational interests (Dickson 1968; Bonnie and Whitebread 1974; Peyrot 1984),[1] the 1986 War on

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Drugs at first glance appears to have resulted from public concern over drug consumption. Thus, we test a model which stipulates that politicians always respond to the demands of the public rather than create them.

Theoretical Framework

It is now widely accepted by sociologists that any social problem consists of two elements: an objective condition and its constructed definition. The most ardent objectivists will admit that claims making contributes to the process in which a condition comes to be defined as problematic and worthy of intervention. Likewise, the vast majority of social constructionists will admit that there is usually an observable basis for the claims of activists. What they disagree about is the relative importance of conditions and definitions. Siding with the constructionists, we select the pluralistically-grounded model developed by Mauss (1975, 1984, 1989) to analyze the 1986 War on Drugs.

The most recent major contributions to the social constructionist perspective in addition to Mauss were made by Spector and Kitsuse (1973, 1977). While there are several differences between their approaches, they share a complete reliance on definitions rather than conditions. Mauss's approach differs from that of Spector and Kitsuse in that he integrates social movement literature into the study of social problems. His approach emphasizes the similarity between social problems and social movements. He argues that social problems are a special kind of movement that begin at the grass-roots level (Mauss 1975, 1984, 1989). For the present purposes, his model is the most relevant because it is based on an ideology of how social problems should arise in a democratic society originating at the popular level and growing to later influence governmental representatives and public policy. While this position has been confirmed for the construction of a number of social problems, we argue that a condition can come to be defined as problematic by powerful interests without the prior existence of a social movement.

Following an established tradition in the study of social movements, Mauss (1975) argued that social problems go through five stages: incipiency, coalescence, institutionalization, fragmentation and demise.

Incipiency

In this stage there is neither strong leadership nor an organized membership in the emerging movement. Members of a public are concerned with the issue at this stage, but no formal organizations exist to champion the cause or to espouse the ideals of the movement.

Coalescence

Mauss (1975:62) stated that in this stage "formal and informal organizations develop out of segments of the sympathetic public that have become the most

aroused by perceived threats to the preservation or realization of their interests."

Institutionalization

This stage is reached "when the government and other traditional institutions take official notice of a problem or movement and work out a series of standard coping mechanisms to manage it" (Mauss 1975:63). Institutionalization is marked by a societal-wide organization of groups involved in the problem, lobbying efforts, and attention in the mass media. This is when the movement reaches its peak of success and influence. Government actions adopt movement-inspired programs to deal with the problem.

Fragmentation

Fragmentation occurs primarily in response to co-optation in the previous stage. Many members of the movement perceive their goals to be achieved in the institutionalization stage with the passage of programs supported by the activists to resolve the problem.

Demise

Demise represents the final stage. With claims makers losing interest in the issue following co-optive legislation and programs, and since many of the leaders have been "brought off" by the establishment, only a dedicated core of true believers is left to carry on the fight.

In this article we examine the extent to which the recently rediscovered drug abuse problem conforms to this pluralistically-based model. In the next section, we present data indicating the absence of a rise in the overall consumption of illicit drugs during recent years.[2] Following that section, we trace public opinion surrounding the issue and the construction of the social problem. Factors serving to precipitate the "creation" of the drug problem are then discussed. In a concluding section we discuss the implications of the findings for social problems theory.

Trends in Illicit Drug Use

The 1986 War on Drugs seems to be based on the assumption of a sizeable increase in the use/abuse of illicit drugs in recent years. In order to evaluate this assumption, we turn to national self-reports of drug use.[3] The most comprehensive of the national surveys is produced by the National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA). This self-report study questions nationally representative samples of persons 12 years of age and older. Data are available from this source for selected years.[4]

Regarding marijuana – the most commonly used illicit drug – the NIDA data show that lifetime, annual and monthly prevalence peaked in 1979 for youth (ages 12–17) and young adults (ages 18–25). Older adults (age 26 and older)

show a different pattern. Monthly and annual use peaked in 1982 for older adults with a slight drop in 1985, whereas lifetime prevalence continued to increase through 1985. This increase in the latter is partially an artifact of the younger groups with higher lifetime prevalence rates simply growing into older adulthood. Given the monthly and annual trends we conclude that marijuana use is decreasing in the younger age groups and remains relatively stable or is decreasing among older adults (National Institute on Drug Abuse 1986).

While cocaine has been the focus of publicity in the recent war on drugs, use of this drug is declining or remaining stable among youth and young adults. Lifetime prevalence rates peaked in 1982 for youth and young adults and declined in 1985. Annual and monthly use have remained stable since 1979 for youth, whereas both peaked in 1979 for young adults and have subsequently declined. Among older adults, all three measures continue to increase with monthly use reaching a relatively small 2.1% in 1985 (National Institute on Drug Abuse 1986).

The NIDA survey does contain information which may add objective support to the war on drugs. In 1985, 21% of cocaine users had tried freebase. Due to the rapid onset and short duration of the effects, smoking freebase is considered dangerous and appears to result in more rapid development of dependency on the drug (National Institute on Drug Abuse n.d.).

Because any conclusions about more recent trends are limited by the years available in the NIDA data set, we turn to information from the Monitoring the Future project. This research is based on a representative smaple of all seniors in public and private high schools in the coterminous United States. Self-report data are available each year since 1975. In addition to surveying high school seniors, the Monitoring the Future project has followed up representative samples from each graduating class beginning with the class of 1976. These data do not include information from high school dropouts, of course.[5]

Trends in the lifetime prevalence of any illicit drug use show that from 1975 to 1979 the proportion of high school seniors involved steadily increased (see Table 1). This was primarily due to increases in marijuana use. This trend crested in 1979–1981. Following this peak in use, involvement with any illicit drug gradually declined through 1986. Trends in annual and monthly use are similar to the lifetime prevalence pattern with the exception of a very small increase in 1985 (Johnston, O'Malley and Bachman 1986; The University of Michigan 1987). Marijuana use followed a similar pattern. Trends in cocaine use are also generally similar, but diverged in 1985 when use among high school seniors rose to its highest point. In 1986 all trends in cocaine use declined except daily use which remained stable at 0.4%.[6]

Among post-high school cohorts, patterns in the index of any illicit drug use and of marijuana use generally parallel those of the high school seniors (Johnston, O'Malley and Bachman 1986;153, 156–157). However, the trends in annual cocaine use are mixed by age group among the post-high school cohorts.

Table 1
Trends in Lifetime, Annual, Monthly, and Daily Use of Illicit Drugs by Graduating High School Seniors

	Class of											
	1975	1976	1977	1978	1979	1980	1981	1982	1983	1984	1985	1986[a]
	% Reporting Use in Lifetime											
DI[b]	55.2	58.3	61.6	64.1	65.1	65.4	65.6	**64.4**	**62.9**	**61.6**	**60.6**	**58.0**
Marij.	47.3	52.8	56.4	59.2	60.4	60.3	59.5	58.7	57.0	54.9	54.2	50.9
Coca.	9.0	9.7	10.8	12.9	15.4	15.7	16.5	16.0	16.2	16.1	17.3	16.9
	% Reporting Use in Last Twelve Months											
DI[b]	45.0	48.1	51.1	53.8	54.2	53.1	52.1	**49.4**	**47.4**	**45.8**	**46.3**	**N/A**
Marij.	40.0	44.5	47.6	50.2	50.8	48.8	46.1	44.3	42.3	40.0	40.6	38.8
Coca.	5.6	6.0	7.2	9.0	12.0	12.3	12.4	11.5	11.4	11.6	13.1	12.7
	% Reporting Use in Last 30 Days											
DI[b]	30.7	34.2	37.6	38.9	38.9	37.2	36.9	**32.5**	**30.5**	**29.2**	**29.7**	**27.0**
Marij.	27.1	32.2	35.4	37.1	36.5	33.7	31.6	28.5	27.0	25.2	25.7	23.4
Coca.	1.9	2.0	2.9	3.9	5.7	5.2	5.8	5.0	4.9	5.8	6.7	6.2
	% Reporting Daily Use in Last 30 Days											
Marij.	6.0	8.2	9.1	10.7	10.3	9.1	7.0	6.3	5.5	5.0	4.9	4.0
Coca.	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.2	0.2	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.4	0.4

Sources: Johnston, O'Malley and Bachman (1986:42-45, 47); The University of Michigan (1987).

[a] Data for 1986 represent estimated percentages. Bold figures are based on the revised version.
[b] DI stands for an Index of Illicit Drug Use or Drug Index. Drugs included in this index are marijuana, hallucinogens, cocaine, heroin, or use of any other opiates, stimulants, sedatives, or tranquilizers not under a physician's orders.

Annual prevalence has dropped in some cohorts since 1982, risen in others and has been stable in one. Still, cocaine use rises substantially with age in these samples (Johnston, O'Malley and Bachman 1986:150, 159).

In conclusion, these data reveal a picture of an overall decline in the use of illicit drugs since the late 1970s and early 1980s. While cocaine use has increased slightly among older adults and was at high levels among high school seniors at the time the war on drugs was initiated, these increases in use of one illegal drug among two age groups in the total population do not support the claim of a new "crisis" in illicit drug use.

Public Opinion and the Drug Issue

One of the tenets of the social constructionist perspective is that moral entrepreneurs or claims makers influence public opinion in their efforts to create a social problem. Thus it is useful to examine trends in public opinion when tracing the natural history of a social problem. According to Gallup surveys, drug abuse was not seen as a major social problem in the years 1981 through 1984. A summary of the "most important problem" for this time period

fails to list drug abuse as a separate category. However, it was presumably included in the poll reports in the category "all others" (*The Gallup Report* 1984). Throughout 1985 and in January 1986 only 2% to 3% of the population ranked it as the most important problem. In fact, drug abuse was a distant fourth on the list of "most important problems facing this country" during the week of July 11–14, 1986 (*The Gallup Report* 1986). This was prior to President Reagan's declaration of a new war on drugs in early August 1986.

A *New York Times*/CBS poll conducted during the week of August 18–26, 1986, found that drugs were considered to be the nation's most important problem with 13% of the respondents ranking it as such. This represented a substantial increase from the 2% who considered drugs the most important problem in a similar poll conducted during April 1986 (Clymer 1986). Along the same lines, a *U.S. News*/CNN poll conducted in late August found that "fighting the drug problem" was most often rated as "extremely important" (i.e., 86% of the respondents did so). It can be inferred from these two surveys in August 1986 that drug abuse was one of the most important, if not the most important, social problem in the eyes of the public at that time (*U.S. News and World Report* 1986a).

A narrower indicator of public concern with drug abuse is contained in the 1986 Gallup poll of attitudes toward the public schools conducted in April 1986. Reviewing the findings of this survey, Alec Gallup concluded, "For the first time in this survey's 18-year history, the U.S. public has identified drug use by students as the most important problem facing the public schools" (1986:44). While about 30% of the respondents ranked drugs as the most important problem confronting the public schools in 1986, only about 20% did so between 1982 and 1985 and about 15% in 1981 (Gallup 1986). Thus, it appears that the American public was concerned about drug use/abuse before the war on drugs was launched, but perceptions of it as an important problem were primarily limited to the public schools. It was following a declaration of war that the drug problem was catapulted into national prominence.

Precipitating Factors

One factor precipitating the creation of a war on drugs lies in Blumer's (1951) distinction between "general social movements" and "specific social movements." A general social movement is characterized by public concern over an issue, or a set of issues, without any orchestrated action on behalf of these concerns. Specific social movements often arise out of general social movements as a result of the formation of interest groups.

The 1986 War on Drugs can be seen in this context. The end of the last decade and the first half of the 1980s were characterized by a conservative mood both in terms of fiscal and certain social issues. The election of Ronald Reagan for two terms and Republican control of the Senate for six years were perhaps the best indicators of the prevailing political climate. In addition, a number of

political issues related to drug use/abuse arose that only a few years earlier were not widely accepted, and some of which would have almost certainly engendered strong opposition. Driving under the influence of alcohol became a major issue beginning in 1982 and crested in 1984. Politicians competed with each other to be seen as the toughest on drunk drivers. Also, a concerted effort was initiated to raise the drinking age to 21 in all states, ostensibly in an attempt to reduce drunk driving. Drug testing also emerged as a social issue with the 1986 War on Drugs (cf., Trebach 1987; Gerber et al. 1990). Capital punishment for specified drug-related crimes and elimination of the exclusionary rule under certain circumstances were also being discussed as part of the arsenal in the war on drugs. Somewhat further removed from drugs, the rights of individuals, defended by conservatives on certain issues, were being challenged by the increasing use of AIDS testing and lie detectors in a variety of settings. Thus, it was in this general setting of conservatism that drugs could again emerge as a leading social problem.

A second triggering factor was the anti-drug campaign of Nancy Reagan. When Ronald Reagan was elected President in 1980, Nancy Reagan was portrayed by the media as a cold and insensitive person whose chief concern seemed to be her wardrobe. Because of this portrayal she sought to change her public image. The primary issue she chose to focus on was drug abuse, although she apparently had considered other campaigns (Beck 1981). While her work with drugs may have been initially little more than "a splendid public relations vehicle for the Reagan White House" (Trebach 1987:121), it received extensive media coverage and provided an underpinning for the creation of the drug problem in 1986.

The news media can play a crucial role in shaping images of social issues (Schneider 1985). In an effort to gauge the influence of the print media as a precipitating factor in the construction of the drug problem, we counted citations in *The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature*. Table 2 presents the number of articles on illicit drugs that were published between 1975 and 1986.[7] The data show that there was relatively little coverage of drug use/abuse from 1975 to 1977. A review of the articles published during these years indicates that use of marijuana received the most coverage, while heroin and cocaine were not major concerns.

There was a significant increase in the coverage of illicit drugs in the print media starting in 1978 and peaking in 1979 and 1980. Marijuana was still the drug receiving most of the press coverage. A number of developments occurred, however, that changed the focus of attention. A number of well-known individuals were either arrested for possession or sale of drugs, or received attention in conjunction with illicit drugs. Hamilton Jordan, a former member of the Carter administration, was arrested on cocaine charges in 1979. Paul McCartney's marijuana-related arrest in Japan received widespread media coverage in the United States in 1980. That same year, Richard Pryor

Table 2
Number of Articles Indexed in The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature Concerning the Use and Abuse of Illicit Drugs

	1975	1976	1977	1978	1979	1980	1981	1982	1983	1984	1985	1986
Sports[a]	1	1	0	4	6	6	4	32	115	65	94	72
Abuse[b]	40	29	38	57	99	98	65	102	97	83	99	198
Totals	41	30	38	61	105	104	69	134	212	148	193	270

Source: **The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature** 1975–1986.

[a] This row includes all articles indexed in **The Readers' Guide** that deal with the use and abuse of illicit drugs by athletes.
[b] This row includes all other articles indexed in **The Readers' Guide** that deal with the use and abuse of illicit drugs.

suffered serious burns in the process of freebasing cocaine. Suspicions that Elvis Presley had died of a drug overdose in 1977 were also renewed in 1980 (Williams 1980). For a two-year period, therefore, illicit drugs were considered newsworthy and received considerable coverage, at least in part due to the fact that several celebrities became associated with drugs.

While 1981 proved to be a relatively calm year without extensive media coverage of illicit drugs, 1982 signaled another increase in media attention to drugs. Several events were responsible for this trend. Drug use of athletes was covered frequently beginning in 1983. This coverage began with the NFL and then spread to baseball and other sports. The use of steroids, an issue long present in sports, also received considerable attention when 14 athletes were disqualified from the Pan American Games in 1983 (Castro 1983). Furthermore, the drug-related death of John Belushi received considerable attention in 1982. Another major event in terms of publicity was the arrest and trial of John DeLorean on cocaine charges. As a result of the above events marijuana was no longer the primary drug of concern. An increasing number of articles were published on the use of cocaine and its consequences.

More articles were published on drugs in 1984 than in any previous year except 1983. However, it was a relatively calm year compared to what was to come. The use of drugs in major league baseball received extensive coverage during the summer of 1984. Several well-known players such as Vida Blue and Willie Wilson entered treatment programs – events that were well covered by the media. Cocaine had by now replaced marijuana as the drug most often covered in the print media. These trends continued in 1985. Cocaine and the use of drugs by athletes were the two most important concerns, but new issues also emerged. The commissioner of major league baseball announced mandatory drug testing. Drug testing in general was beginning to receive more media coverage than in previous years. A few articles were also published on designer drugs.

As can be seen from the above, the emergence of drugs as one of the most important social problems in 1986 was not unexpected. Drugs had attracted media attention throughout the late 1970s and the first half of the 1980s. More precisely, coverage increased whenever a newsworthy event occurred (cf., Kielbowicz and Scherer 1986).

A record number of articles were published on the issue of drug use/abuse during 1986 (see Table 2). Two key factors contributed to an increase in the attention paid to illicit drugs during the late spring and summer of 1986. First, widespread publicity about crack stimulated public and political concerns over illicit drugs. Crack use was seen as an epidemic spreading throughout the major cities of the nation. Second was the cocaine-related deaths of two well known athletes, Len Bias and Don Rogers.

The New War on Drugs: 1986

In order to trace the events involved in the social construction of the 1986 War on Drugs, we supplemented our review of articles in *The Readers' Guide* with a review of the index of *The New York Times*. It is apparent from the newspaper's coverage that concern over crack use received a great deal of attention from mid-May through late June. Beginning in early June, community and church groups in the New York City area staged several vigils and public demonstrations to publicize the spread of crack and related problems. Several more demonstrations were conducted in late July and early August. This activity indicates the beginning of a coalescence stage of the natural history of the new war on drugs.

The June 19 cocaine-related death of Len Bias focused media and public attention on drug abuse among athletes and cocaine abuse in general. An outpouring of newspaper and magazine articles followed his death. The June 27 death of Don Rogers was also later linked to cocaine abuse.

These events did not go unnoticed by politicians. On July 9, *The New York Times* carried a brief news note stating that President Reagan was considering taking the lead from Mrs. Reagan and launching an anti-drug campaign (1986a). Two days later another article appeared indicating that the President would start an anti-drug drive soon (1986b). On July 23, House Speaker Thomas O'Neill and other Democratic leaders announced a bipartisan effort to combat illicit drugs which received front page coverage in the *Times* (1986c). Within days, the *Times* carried a story on who really took the anti-drug initiative: Nancy Reagan, House Democrats, or President Reagan (1986d). The political football game had begun.

On August 1, Democratic leaders beat President Reagan to the punch and outlined a major anti-drug bill (1986e). President Reagan followed this legislative initiative a few days later by announcing his new anti-drug drive and calling for mandatory drug tests for federal workers in sensitive positions (1986f). Republican leaders then jumped into the fray and pressured the

President to seize the drug issue before the Democrats could make it their own (1986g, 1986h).

By mid-to-late August the drug issue had swept the nation. As discussed above, polls showed it to be one of the most important problems in the nation, whereas only months before it received only a few percentage points in these surveys. As summer turned to fall it was apparent that drugs had become a major campaign issue with both Republicans and Democrats maneuvering to gain political mileage from this wholesome, safe issue (1986i, 1986j, 1986l). On September 11, in an overwhelming vote of 392 to 16, the House passed its version of an anti-drug bill. Three days later President and Mrs. Reagan made an unprecedented joint television address to the nation on the drug problem. On September 15, President Reagan presented his bill to Congress (1986k). After a month of debate on the specifics of the bill, on October 17 the Senate passed a $1.7 billion compromise drug bill and President Reagan signed it into law on October 28.

In a matter of months a social problem had been constructed and reached a policy formation stage with the enactment of federal legislation. By December press coverage of the "new" drug problem had diminished substantially (see Table 3).

Table 3
Number of Articles Indexed in 1986 in The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature Concerning the Use and Abuse of Illicit Drugs, by Month of Publication

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
Sports	4	11	11	6	4	5	13	8	3	4	2	1
Abuse	4	6	19	11	7	20	14	25	27	25	24	16
Combined	8	17	30	17	11	25	27	33	30	29	26	17

Source: **The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature**, 1986.

Theoretical Implications

We set out to analyze the creation of a social problem by using the model developed by Mauss (1975), a framework that stipulates the emergence of public concern prior to governmental actions. We were interested in explaining an apparent discrepancy between public and political fervor over the drug issue in 1986, and objective data that indicated no significant increases in the consumption of illicit drugs. We found some support for this model, albeit with important modifications.

It is apparent from the history of this problem that an incipiency stage existed for the new war on drugs. While public opinion polls just prior to the "creation" of the drug problem found a very small proportion of respondents identifying

drug abuse pre se as the most important problem in the nation, the public considered drug use by students to be the most important problem facing the public schools.

Publicity surrounding crack and the cocaine-related deaths of Len Bias and Don Rogers spurred renewed interest in the drug issue during mid-May and June 1986. Evidence of the coalescence stage is found at this time in the emergence of interest group efforts to publicize and combat crack use in New York City. However, the coalescence stage did not fully develop as proposed by Mauss (1975). The groups that were forming and responding to the crack "epidemic" remained localized and rather ineffectual. Instead of a wave of new grass-roots organizations or existing voluntary associations championing the problem, politicians gathered around the issue only months before the 1986 Congressional elections. A new war on drugs was their answer to a lackluster campaign season. Proposals for tax reform and the administration's attack on pornography were attracting little voter support. Furthermore, President Reagan was "trapped in a thicket of thorny problems, not the least of which were budget and trade deficits and sanctions against South Africa" (*U.S. News and World Report* 1986b:28). Drugs were a safe issue for incumbent politicians who wanted to take the "moral high road" on an issue (see Gerber et al. 1990; Ben-Yehuda 1986; Nelson 1984; *Newsweek* 1986; *U.S. News and World Report* 1986a, 1986b).

The development of this social problem jumped from the beginnings of a coalescence stage directly into an early part of what Mauss labeled the institutionalization stage. This occurred first when Congressional Democrats announced on July 23 a bipartisan effort to pass legislation to combat drug abuse and proposed an anti-drug bill on August 1. The construction of a drug problem was reaffirmed when President Reagan announced his anti-drug effort a few days later. This process continued in mid-September when the House overwhelmingly passed its version of the anti-drug bill, and President and Mrs. Reagan made their joint televised address to the nation. Formal creation of the problem and policy formation culminated in mid-October when the drug bill was passed and signed into law by the President, only two weeks before the elections.

The history of this social problem further deviated from the Mauss model at this point in its development. The politicians who had "created" the problem needed public support for their positions. All of the actions described above thus served two functions: on one hand they represented something similar to the institutionalization stage of Mauss's model, but on the other they served as mechanisms to attract public support. While the Mauss model predicts the intensification of public concern first (coalescence), which is then followed by official recognition, we argue that this social problem was institutionalized before public concern went beyond early coalescence. Support for this

contention can be found in the fact that public concern over the drug issue, as measured in opinion polls, escalated after politicians promoted it.

Our argument is not entirely novel. Chauncey (1980), for instance, studied the efforts of the National Institute on Alcohol Abuse and Alcoholism (NIAAA) against teenage drinking. He concluded that the objective conditions of teenage drinking were not nearly as serious as NIAAA maintained. Instead, he argued, the social problem was "created" by NIAAA for organizational reasons, and public support was subsequently sought in an effort to legitimate NIAAA's claims.

Randall and Short (1983) also found support for this type of model. They studied the involvement of the Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA) in a controversy surrounding a company's decision to prevent fertile female employees from occupying certain positions with lead exposure. When OSHA became involved in the controversy, it extended, by definition, official recognition to the problem. OSHA then initiated a campaign designed to legitimate its claims.

Similarly, Gerber (1984) and Gerber and Short (1986) studied the claims making concerning the marketing and selling of infant formula in less developed countries. While there were numerous grass-roots organizations that applied pressure on corporations (e.g., by organizing a boycott of Nestlé products), governmental and quasi-governmental agencies such as the World Health Organization were involved in the process of claims making from the very beginning. Here again the social problem did not advance through the stages in the sequence Mauss predicted. While there was an incipiency, the stages of coalescence and institutionalization were meshed together, with the latter actually preceding coalescence in some ways.

We argue in light of the present study and studies cited above that the Mauss model should be revised for those social problems in which state officials or governmental agencies are the claims makers.[8] Drawing from the work of Randall and Short (1983), we propose the following revision of the Mauss (1975) natural history model to fit the construction of social problems by state officials: incipiency, coalescence, creation and policy formation and legitimation.

Incipiency

In this stage there is neither strong leadership nor an organized membership in the emerging claims making activities. Some members of the general public may be concerned with the issue at this stage but no formal organizations exist to champion the cause.

Coalescence

A stage of coalescence may or may not occur. If it does, formal and informal organiations emerge from segments of the sympathetic public that have become the most concerned about perceived threats to their interests.

Creation and Policy Formation

Politicians or a government agency assert the existence of an undesirable condition, advocate the legitimacy of their claims, and propose a remedy for the "problem" in an effort to advance their own interests (Randall and Short 1983).

Legitimation

By publicizing their claims, politicians or other state officials will attempt to generate public support for their position. Furthermore, these state officials need to establish the legitimacy of their "mandate regarding both claims and solutions which are favorable" to their interests (Randall and Short 1983:421).

A short-lived fragmentation of the drug problem followed the legitimation stage. With the elections concluded and a major federal bill in effect, most politicians returned to business-as-usual. The drug problem continued to be important to the public throughout 1987 and early 1988, but slipped out of the politicial limelight (see *The Gallup Report* 1987).

With the advent of the presidential campaign season during the spring of 1988, political claims makers revived the drug issue. Opinion polls indicated that drugs were an important issue in the presidential election (see *The Spokesman Review* 1988; *The Chronicle of Higher Education* 1988; *Newsweek* 1988). The drug issue has been firmly constructed in the public eye. While the demise of the drug "problem" cannot be predicted, researchers will continue to monitor claims-making activities and policy outcomes of this most recent war on drugs.

NOTES

1. A notable exception to this statement is Galliher and Walker (1977).

2. Our primary objective is not to "prove" that out interpretation of drug "facts" is correct while activists involved in the 1986 War on Drugs were wrong. To do so would indeed involve "ontological gerrymandering" as Woolgar and Pawluch (1985) contend. Following Phohl (1985), our goal is more humble – to "deconstruct" the official version of drug use during the 1980s, and especially in 1986. We try to show that participants in the war on drugs created a social problem without consulting an important data base that was available to them: self-report surveys.

3. We reject data such as arrest statistics and conviction rates as valid measures of drug consumption because official statistics are subject to priorities of enforcement agencies. In other works, if police spend more resources on combating drug use and abuse, arrest statistics will go up irrespective of the objective conditions of drug use. While self-report statistics have problems, they are a more accurate method of measuring "actual" drug use for the present purposes than are the former.

4. Dates of the NIDA surveys relevant to this research are 1972, 1974, 1976, 1977, 1979, 1982 and 1985 (National Institute on Drug Abuse 1986).

5. See Johnston, O'Malley and Bachman (1986) for a discussion of the problems associated with the exclusion of high school dropouts from these surveys.

6. The high school senior survey also contains some initial descriptive data on the use of crack. A little over 4% of the respondents had used crack in the year prior to the 1986 survey. Crack users were demographically similar to users of powdered cocaine, but the crack user is even more concentrated among non-college-bound students. As of 1985–86 crack appeared to be available throughout the country, but use was higher in urban areas and in the North-eastern and Westerm regions (The University of Michigan 1987).

7. All articles cited in *The Readers' Guide* dealing with the use of illicit drugs were recorded. As is often the case in such studies, articles dealing with a certain subject are indexed under a relatively small number of keywords if the issue is not covered extensively. However, once the issue becomes popular, an increasing number of articles are published and they are indexed under more specific keywords. We identified all relevant keywords and then recorded the articles. The list of keywords that were eventually used would be too extensive to reprint here. Interested researchers can contact the authors and a list will be provided.

8. For other discussions of officially created social problems, see Nelson (1984) and Ben-Yehuda (1986).

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